

A2/AD and the South China Sea

China is not trying to win a fleet battle. It is trying to make American sea control too expensive to use.

The balance in the South China Sea has not flipped, but it has shifted at the level of will and continuity rather than raw capability — and the trend line only points one way until the US shows it will pay to reverse it.

The South China Sea carries about 3.4 trillion dollars of trade a year, along with a fifth of the world's oil, and the question of who controls it is being settled right now. The usual way to read the contest is capability against capability: count China's ships, count America's carriers, compare. That framing misses what China is actually doing.

China is not building a navy to defeat the US Navy. It is building an architecture that makes American sea control too expensive to exercise. The DF-21D missile puts carrier groups at risk out to 1,500 kilometres, covering the entire First Island Chain; the DF-26 reaches Guam at 4,000, and carries both conventional and nuclear warheads. The artificial islands in the Spratlys, some 1,300 hectares of reclaimed land since 2013, extend radar coverage and missile range into the middle of the sea. A quiet diesel-electric submarine fleet, hard to detect in the sea's shallow, thermally layered waters, makes every US operational plan start with an anti-submarine problem. Jamming stations and anti-satellite weapons threaten the information layer everything else depends on. None of this is built to win a battle. It is built to change the maths before any shot is fired.

There is a historical name for this. Before the First World War, Admiral Tirpitz built a German fleet that could never beat the Royal Navy but could make British naval dominance too costly to enforce. Sea denial, not sea control. China has taken the same logic and rebuilt it with missiles, islands and electronic warfare instead of battleships. The aim is narrow and precise: not to change what the US Navy is, only to change what it calculates before entering one specific body of water.

The missiles are the visible layer. The daily work happens lower. China's coast guard, now one of the largest and most heavily armed in the world, blocks Philippine resupply runs with water cannon and lasers. A maritime militia of nominally civilian fishing boats keeps a permanent presence in disputed waters. No single incident crosses the threshold that would justify a military response, and any response to a "civilian" vessel carries a legitimacy cost. Each move is small. The accumulation is the strategy.

The American reaction has been real but limited. Freedom of navigation operations keep the legal claim alive without changing anything on the water; Beijing files a protest after each one and continues building. The doctrinal shift from AirSea Battle to

JAM-GC adapted operational planning to a denial environment. The alliance network has thickened: QUAD, AUKUS, expanded base access in the Philippines. Japan is now building its own denial layer along the Ryukyus, turning the logic back on Beijing.

The 2016 Hague ruling declared China's nine-dash-line claims invalid under UNCLOS, and construction continued the next day. There is also a quieter problem underneath the legal argument: the United States builds its case on UNCLOS, a treaty it has never ratified. Beijing does not miss the opening.

The balance in the South China Sea has not flipped. But it has shifted, and the shift happened at the level of will and continuity rather than raw capability. China made its presence permanent, physically and operationally. The US has not yet shown it is willing to pay what reversing that would cost. Until it does, the trend line only points one way.

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